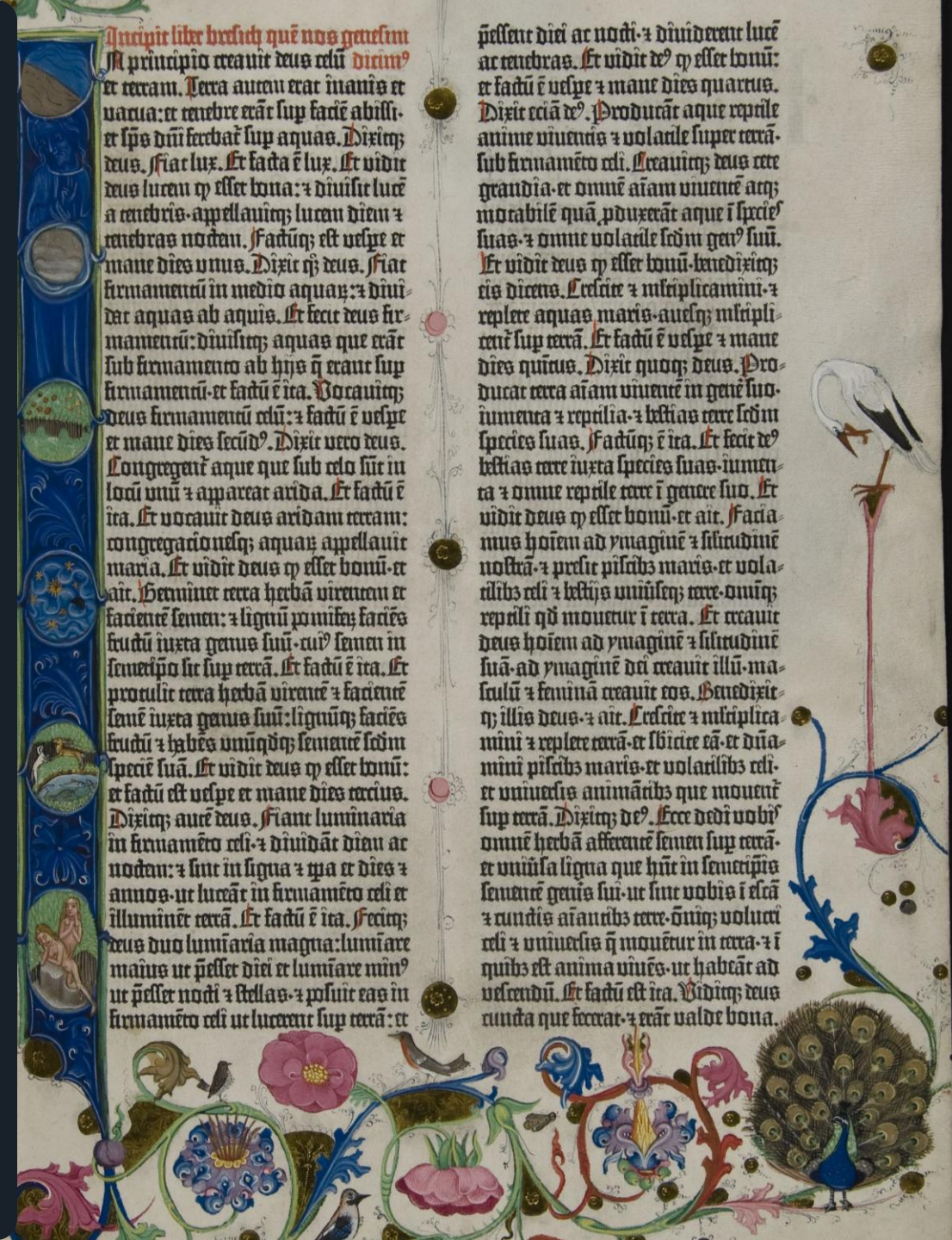


Typography and Visual Hierarchy

Week 3: What a reader notices first, and why



The Week 3 question

Given the same words, why does one layout read easily and another feel like work?

Why it matters: readers scan before they read. A clear type scale and hierarchy let them find the right entry point in seconds.

Verification: apply the rule to a real page, then check it at both a narrow and a wide viewport width.

Evidence to record: rule applied, page checked, viewport width and observed result.

From meaning to legibility

Week 2 gave the document a correct outline. Week 3 decides how that outline is seen, scanned and understood at a glance.

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Evidence to record: rule applied, page checked, viewport width and observed result.

Learning outcomes



Type scale

Choose a consistent ratio and apply it to every heading level.



Measure and leading

Keep lines readable in length and comfortably spaced.



Contrast check

Verify colour pairs pass WCAG 2.1 AA before shipping.

Anatomy of a letterform

Baseline, x-height, ascenders and descenders together decide how a typeface performs at small sizes on screen.

Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.



Serif, sans-serif, monospace

**Serif suits long print-like reading. Sans-serif suits screens and UI.
Monospace signals code or tabular data.**

Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.

A large, bold, black serif font example showing the uppercase letter 'B' and the lowercase letter 'b'. The letters are thick and have a classic, elegant design with a slight curve to the top of the 'B' and a loop at the bottom of the 'b'.

Choosing and pairing typefaces

Pair a distinct heading face with a highly legible body face — the same discipline that separated capital letters from lower case in the printer's own type case.

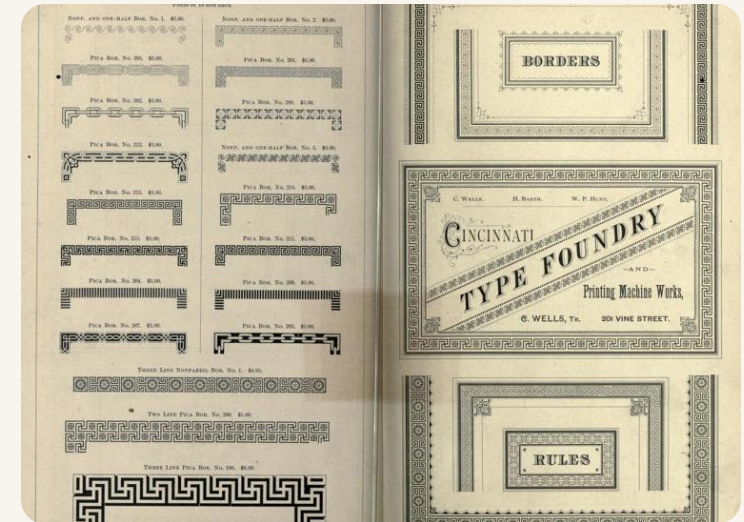
Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.



Type specimens as a reference

Type foundries published specimen sheets so a designer could compare weight, size and spacing before setting a page. A modern web type scale serves the same purpose.

Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.



Type scale

A type scale is a small set of related sizes, not a random list. Consistency makes hierarchy predictable.

Why it matters: readers scan before they read. A clear type scale and hierarchy let them find the right entry point in seconds.

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Evidence to record: rule applied, page checked, viewport width and observed result.

Modular scale example

```
<style>
:root {
  --step-0: 1rem;
  --step-1: 1.25rem;
  --step-2: 1.563rem;
  --step-3: 1.953rem;
  --step-4: 2.441rem;
}
</style>
```

Read the code as a rule: what does it fix, and what does it leave flexible?

Measure: line length

Aim for 45 to 75 characters per line. Shorter lines fragment thought; longer lines lose the start of the next line.

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Verification: apply the rule to a real page, then check it at both a narrow and a wide viewport width.

Evidence to record: rule applied, page checked, viewport width and observed result.

Setting measure in CSS

```
<style>
.prose {
  max-width: 65ch;
  margin-inline: auto;
}
</style>
```

Read the code as a rule: what does it fix, and what does it leave flexible?

Leading and measure interact

Body text reads best around 1.4 to 1.6 line height. A wider measure needs looser leading so the eye can find the next line.

Why it matters: readers scan before they read. A clear type scale and hierarchy let them find the right entry point in seconds.

Verification: apply the rule to a real page, then check it at both a narrow and a wide viewport width.

Evidence to record: rule applied, page checked, viewport width and observed result.

Letter spacing and tracking

Increase tracking slightly for small capitals or short labels. A hand compositor spaced individual wood letters the same way — by eye, one gap at a time.

Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.



What visual hierarchy is

An ordered set of size, weight, colour, spacing and position that tells a reader what to read first, second and last.

Why it matters: readers scan before they read. A clear type scale and hierarchy let them find the right entry point in seconds.

Verification: apply the rule to a real page, then check it at both a narrow and a wide viewport width.

Evidence to record: rule applied, page checked, viewport width and observed result.

Hierarchy without new markup

CSS already has the h1 to h6 outline to work with. Style existing structure before inventing new wrapper elements.

Why it matters: readers scan before they read. A clear type scale and hierarchy let them find the right entry point in seconds.

Verification: apply the rule to a real page, then check it at both a narrow and a wide viewport width.

Evidence to record: rule applied, page checked, viewport width and observed result.

Size, weight and colour as signals

**Increase size and weight together for the most important text.
Each metal sort in a composing stick was one deliberate, sized
decision — CSS hierarchy is the same discipline, just faster to
change.**

Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.



Whitespace creates grouping

Related items sit close together. Unrelated items are separated by larger gaps. Proximity is a hierarchy tool, not empty space.

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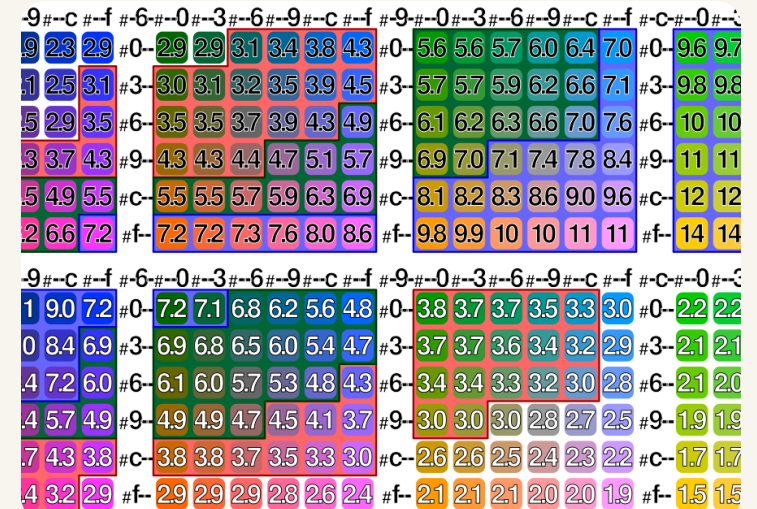
Verification: apply the rule to a real page, then check it at both a narrow and a wide viewport width.

Evidence to record: rule applied, page checked, viewport width and observed result.

Contrast for legibility

WCAG 2.1 AA requires 4.5:1 for normal body text and 3:1 for large text (24px or 19px bold and above).

Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.



Responsive type with clamp()

```
<style>
h1 {
  font-size: clamp(1.75rem, 4vw + 1rem, 3rem);
}
</style>
```

Read the code as a rule: what does it fix, and what does it leave flexible?

Relative units: rem over px

rem scales with a reader's browser font-size setting. A fixed px value silently ignores accessibility zoom preferences.

Why it matters: readers scan before they read. A clear type scale and hierarchy let them find the right entry point in seconds.

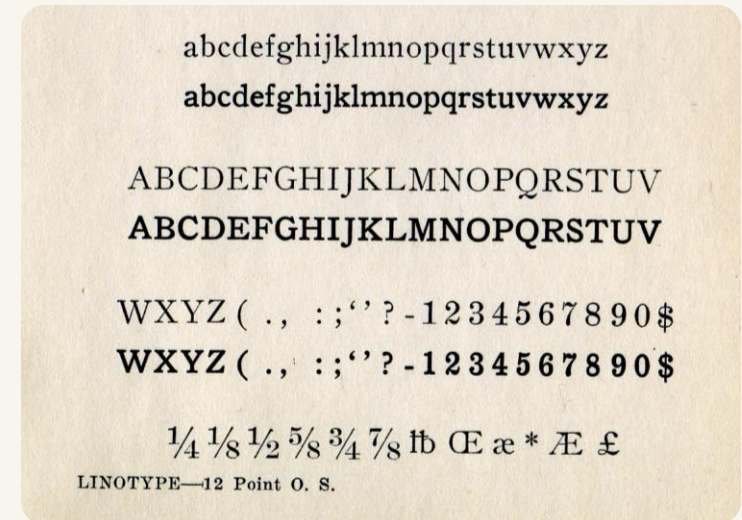
Verification: apply the rule to a real page, then check it at both a narrow and a wide viewport width.

Evidence to record: rule applied, page checked, viewport width and observed result.

Loading web fonts responsibly

A Linotype specimen sheet let a print shop preview a typeface before committing metal to a page. font-display gives a browser the same kind of preview control while a web font downloads.

Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.



font-display and layout shift

```
<style>
  @font-face {
    font-family: "Body";
    src: url("/fonts/body.woff2") format("woff2");
    font-display: swap;
  }
</style>
```

Read the code as a rule: what does it fix, and what does it leave flexible?

Common hierarchy mistakes

Too many sizes, centred body paragraphs, all-caps long text, low-contrast grey-on-white and unstyled default heading tags.

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Evidence to record: rule applied, page checked, viewport width and observed result.

From press to browser

Gutenberg's movable-type press made consistent, repeatable typography possible at scale for the first time. CSS type rules do the same job for a website: one rule, applied everywhere it belongs.

Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.



Studio exercise

Build a five-step type scale with clamp(), apply it to an existing semantic outline from Week 2, then squint at the rendered page — can you still tell what matters most?

Evidence to record: ratio chosen, page tested, viewport width and observed result.

Bring the before/after screenshots and your ratio choice to the next studio session.

Testable review checklist

Type scale

Ratio applied consistently across h1 to h6.

Measure

45–75 characters per line at body size.

Contrast

Body text passes 4.5:1 against its background.

Squint test

Hierarchy still reads with the page blurred.

Image sources and next week

All photographs and diagrams on this deck are freely licensed Wikimedia Commons images (public domain or CC BY / CC BY-SA), credited on the source-record page distributed with these notes. Next week: layout with CSS — turning a well-set type system into flexbox and grid for narrow and wide screens.

Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.

